

Austin Baldi

UX RESEARCHER

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SUMMARY

UX researcher with 3+ years of research experience, including embedded work in early-stage game development, running playtests and localization audits that reach dev teams the same day findings are ready. I work before problems calcify, identifying where players lose the thread, misread mechanics, or disengage, and delivering prioritized findings small teams can act on without slowing the sprint. Currently embedded with Eldritch House on an active Steam demo.

SKILLS

Playtesting: Moderated & Unmoderated Playtests, Think-Aloud Sessions, Hypothesis-Anchored Study Design, New Player Onboarding Research, Genre-Unfamiliar Participant Testing, Localization Audits

Analysis: Frame-by-Frame Video Review, Behavioral Pattern Recognition, Cross-Session Synthesis, Survey Design & Statistical Analysis, Mixed-Methods Synthesis, KPI Definition & Tracking

Tools: ffmpeg, ImageMagick, ReportLab, Dovetail, UserTesting, PlaytestCloud, Figma, Notion, Zoom

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

UX Researcher, Independent Consultant

Nov 2025 – Present

Eldritch House (Brazil, Remote) · Shadow Sacramento: The Roots of Evil · DANGEN Entertainment

Embedded in an active indie studio (public Steam demo). Run iterative playtests across build cycles and deliver prioritized findings reports directly to the development team.

- Flagged a pause menu default cursor position on a destructive action (Load Game rather than Resume), a finding that became a LinkedIn post reaching 18,000+ impressions.
- Identified a 12-minute gap between lantern item acquisition and the game's activation tutorial, leaving players navigating dark areas without understanding how to use a core mechanic.
- Ran a PT-BR localization audit across a 94-minute native speaker playthrough: 1,100+ frames extracted via a custom ffmpeg/ImageMagick pipeline, yielding 7 findings with timestamps and reproduction steps.
- Identified a stealth visual feedback gap: the character model does not communicate a hidden state when crouching, causing players to misread detection as a bug rather than an intended mechanic.

Lead UX Researcher

Jul 2023 – Jan 2026

Dyslexia Foundation Nigeria (Remote) · Accessibility EdTech · via Tech Fleet

- Built research infrastructure from scratch for a distributed volunteer team: participant records, session documentation, and shared planning artifacts, sustained across 3+ research phases over 2.5 years.
- Coordinated mixed-methods research across discovery, competitive benchmarking, and evaluative testing with trainers, caregivers, and educators.
- Synthesized device and connectivity data (97.3% Android usage) to anchor core technical recommendations for the product team.

Apprentice (Phase 1), Co-Lead UX Researcher (Phase 2)

Oct 2022 – May 2023

Kadena (Brooklyn, NY, Remote) · K-Block Blockchain Explorer · via Tech Fleet

- Moved from Phase 1 apprentice to Phase 2 co-lead of an 8-person research team (3 co-leads, 5 apprentices), delivering updated personas, synthesis, and design recommendations at the May 2023 Final Sprint Demo.
- Grew the team's interview base from 2 exploratory interviews in Phase 1 to 9 in Phase 2 (6 participants experienced in crypto and NFT trading, 3 current Kadena users) to update the personas inherited from Phase 1.
- Closed 2 rounds of moderated usability testing (Blockchain Explorer, then NFT Analytics Tool) with the NFT Analytics Tool scoring 6.7 of 7 on the Single Ease Question.
- Presented an NFT analytics competitive analysis at the Sprint 1 kickoff to answer where KBEv2 could fill a gap, and contributed usability task ideas ahead of the joint task session with the design team.
- Covered 1 of 8 competitors (Tradeblock) in the Phase 1 competitive analysis that the Phase 2 team inherited at its March 2023 kickoff.

PROJECTS

Independent Games User Research Study

May 2024

Disney Speedstorm (Gameloft) · Games User Research Fundamentals · gamesuserresearch.com / PlaytestCloud

- Identified recurring confusion around in-game currency and reward systems across 4 of 5 independent sessions, a cross-session pattern pointing to a systemic onboarding gap, not individual variance.
- Ran 5 moderated think-aloud playtests with participants across 4 countries; designed the study, recruited participants, facilitated sessions, and synthesized findings independently without studio access or internal data.

EDUCATION

B.A. Psychology · NC State University